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G.V.K.S. Prasad

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sion is provided to EFY subscribers, wherein they can access the latest issue even before it comes out from the printing press. Look forward to retaining your esteemed patronage.

Simple Soldering Iron Temperature Regulator

I want to know whether the 'Simple Soldering Iron Temperature Regulator' published in the February issue will work with the 230V soldering iron if we remove the step-down transformer and connect the input lines of the transformer directly to the socket of the soldering iron.

Shekhkar Kapoor
Ludhiana

The author T.K. Hareendran replies:

The published circuit was optimised for driving the inductive load and hence it is not recommended for use with 230V. However, with some minor modifications, it can be used for the purpose indicated by you. Such an idea was not tested by me, so I am unable to provide the circuit diagram.

From Facebook: On Firmware Coding

I want to learn firmware coding. Please suggest me a good book.

Vinayak Bhat

□ Firmware runs at the lowest level, and works very closely with the processor. So thorough knowledge of the processor is very, very important. The user application will usually run on top of this firmware, sometimes over an OS which itself runs on this firmware—e.g., your application running on Windows that runs on top of the BIOS.

In most simpler and smaller embedded systems, e.g., simple academic projects like line-following robots, the low-level initiation programs and input/output (I/O) routines and the application itself make up the firmware. In bigger embedded systems, the OS and its set of basic utilities is the firmware which may (e.g., your cellphone) or may not be extendible (e.g., space probes), though it may be upgradeable.

In some sense, the Arduino code library can also be termed as firmware in that it performs low-level initiation programs of the processor and provides a layer of abstraction for higher-level applications. It differs in one aspect though—it does not reside on the Arduino board but is compiled along with the user code.

Anyway, some concepts are universal which can be learnt by studying different systems. There are some standards to follow so that your firmware can be compatible with others. I am not aware of any book dedicated to this topic (a quick search found 'The Firmware Handbook' by Jack Ganssle on Amazon) but most books dealing with embedded systems and computer architecture will discuss firmware development. You can also look for reference projects and code examples provided by manufacturers on their websites (www.ti.com, www.analog.com) for their microcontroller devices.

Garish Pundlik